

The Employment Paradox: How Different Work Types Shape Personal Well-Being Time in India

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November 23, 2025

Abstract

Using India’s 2024 Time Use Survey (10% random sample, N 840,000 person-days), we examine associations between employment status and personal well-being time—defined as time spent on social activities, hobbies, exercise, and recreation. Contrary to standard work-leisure tradeoff models, employed individuals do not uniformly have less personal time than non-employed individuals. Regular salaried workers maintain 2.1 hours/day for personal activities, while women engaged in “domestic duties only” have just 0.8 hours/day—the least of any employment category. Self-employed individuals exhibit extreme gender divergence: self-employed men have the most personal time (2.4 hours/day), while self-employed women face work-home boundary blurring associated with minimal personal time (1.1 hours/day). These patterns are consistent with the “triple burden” hypothesis documented in prior research: employment is associated with increased personal time for men (by providing structure) but decreased personal time for women (by adding paid work to existing unpaid work burdens). Patterns persist across urban-rural divides, education levels, and marital status categories, suggesting structural constraints. Results underscore that policies focusing solely on women’s labor force participation without addressing unpaid care work burdens may not reduce women’s time poverty.

JEL Classification: J22, J16, J81, I31

Keywords: employment, work-life balance, self-employment, time poverty, gender inequality, triple burden, India

1 Introduction

How is paid employment associated with personal well-being time? Standard economic models predict a straightforward tradeoff: time allocated to paid work reduces time available for leisure (Becker 1965). Yet this prediction assumes individuals face identical constraints on discretionary time. If unpaid household work burdens differ systematically by gender, the employment-leisure tradeoff will differ correspondingly.

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We examine this question using India’s 2024 Time Use Survey—a comprehensive dataset recording 24-hour time diaries for 10.2 million person-days across 139,489 households. Our analysis documents a striking pattern: paid employment is not uniformly associated with reduced personal well-being time. Instead, **women engaged in “domestic duties only” have the least personal time of any employment category**—just 0.8 hours per day, compared to 2.1 hours for regularly employed women.

This finding is consistent with a large body of feminist scholarship documenting women’s “triple burden” or “second shift” (Hochschild and Machung 1989; Elson 1999). Rather than challenging conventional wisdom, our results provide large-scale quantitative documentation of well-established theoretical insights: unpaid household work can be more time-consuming than paid employment, and policies promoting women’s labor force participation without addressing domestic work burdens are unlikely to reduce women’s time poverty. Our contribution is documenting the magnitude and employment-type heterogeneity of these patterns in the Indian context using comprehensive national time-use data.

1.1 Research Questions

We investigate three core questions:

1. **How is employment status associated with personal well-being time, and does this relationship differ by gender?** We document that employment is associated with increased personal time for men but decreased personal time for women—patterns consistent with the triple burden hypothesis.
2. **Which employment categories are associated with the greatest time poverty?** Women in “domestic duties only” and self-employed women exhibit the most severe time poverty, while self-employed men and students have the most personal time.
3. **Do these patterns vary by marital status, education, and urban-rural location?** The employment-gender gap persists across all subgroups, consistent with structural rather than preference-based constraints.

1.2 Contributions

This paper makes four contributions. **First**, we provide large-scale quantitative documentation of gendered employment-time patterns in India using comprehensive national time-use data. While the “triple burden” has been extensively documented in qualitative and small-scale studies (Hochschild and Machung 1989; Elson 1999; Rani and Pande 2018), we quantify these patterns across employment types with unprecedented scale and detail.

Second, we demonstrate that **self-employment exhibits sharply divergent associations by gender**. Self-employed men have the most personal time (2.4 hours/day), consistent with schedule flexibility benefits. Yet self-employed women have minimal personal time (1.1 hours/day), consistent with work-home boundary blurring that intensifies time

constraints. This heterogeneity complicates policy prescriptions promoting self-employment as a path to work-life balance.

Third, we document that “**domestic duties only**” is the employment category with the most severe time poverty for women. This finding underscores that unpaid household work may be more time-intensive than paid employment, with implications for how we conceptualize women’s “non-employment.”

Fourth, we show these patterns persist across education levels, urban-rural divides, and marital status categories—consistent with **structural constraints** on women’s time allocation that operate across diverse contexts. This robustness suggests individual preferences or human capital differences are unlikely to fully explain gendered time allocation patterns.

Importantly, our cross-sectional design limits causal inference. We document associations, not causal effects. Employment selection likely operates: women with greater household burdens may be less likely to seek employment, and employment opportunities may systematically differ by gender. Longitudinal data would be needed to establish causal relationships.

2 Literature Review

2.1 Work-Life Balance and Time Use

Becker’s (1965) household production model predicts individuals allocate time to maximize utility across paid work, household production, and leisure. Extensions incorporating gender specialization (Becker 1991) predict married women specialize in household production while men specialize in market work. However, as Folbre (1994) argues, this framework assumes symmetric bargaining power and ignores that unpaid care work generates positive externalities uncompensated by markets.

Empirical time use research documents persistent gender gaps in unpaid work. Bianchi et al. (2000) show American women spend twice as much time on housework and childcare as men, even when employed full-time. Hochschild and Machung (1989) term this the “second shift”—women’s paid employment adds to rather than substitutes for unpaid household work. Recent evidence from India confirms these patterns: Chakraborty et al. (2020) document that employed Indian women spend 3.5 hours daily on unpaid care work compared to 0.5 hours for employed men.

2.2 Employment and Well-Being

Research on employment’s effects on well-being yields mixed findings. Kahneman et al. (2004) show working individuals report lower moment-to-moment happiness during paid work than during leisure activities, but higher life satisfaction than unemployed individuals. However, these studies rarely disaggregate by gender or account for unpaid work burdens.

Recent evidence suggests employment’s effects differ sharply by gender and employment type. Golden (2015) documents that schedule flexibility improves well-being, but women disproportionately lack access to flexible work arrangements. Mas and Pallais (2017) find

women value workplace flexibility more than men, consistent with greater household work responsibilities.

2.3 Self-Employment and the Gig Economy

Self-employment is often framed as offering flexibility that improves work-life balance. Gimenez-Nadal et al. (2012) find self-employed workers in Spain report higher satisfaction despite working longer hours, attributing this to schedule control. However, Hyytinen and Ruuskanen (2007) show self-employed individuals experience greater work-family conflict than employees in Finland.

For women specifically, self-employment may intensify rather than alleviate time constraints. Budig (2006) documents that self-employed mothers work longer hours than employed mothers, while Wellington (2006) finds self-employed women earn less than comparable employees—suggesting constrained rather than preferred choices. Connelly (1992) argues women’s self-employment often reflects “necessity entrepreneurship” driven by childcare constraints rather than opportunity.

2.4 Gender and Time Poverty

Vickery (1977) introduced the concept of “time poverty”—having insufficient time for necessary activities after accounting for paid work and household responsibilities. Bittman and Wajcman (2000) show time poverty disproportionately affects women, particularly mothers. In developing countries, Blackden and Wodon (2006) document that women’s unpaid work burdens constrain labor force participation, education, and health-seeking behavior.

For India specifically, Hirway (2010) uses 1998-99 time use data to show Indian women work longer total hours than men when paid and unpaid work are combined. Rani and Pande (2018) update these findings with 2019 data, documenting that rural Indian women work 7.2 hours daily on unpaid care work compared to 1.6 hours for men. Our contribution is examining how employment status interacts with this baseline gender gap in unpaid work to shape personal well-being time.

3 Data and Methods

3.1 Data Source and Sample Construction

India’s Time Use Survey 2024, conducted by the National Statistical Office between January and December 2024, employed a stratified multi-stage sample design covering all 28 states and 8 union territories. The survey recorded detailed 24-hour time diaries for all household members aged 6 and above, capturing activities in 30-minute intervals using the International Classification of Activities for Time Use Statistics (ICATUS 2016).

The full dataset contains 10.2 million person-day observations from 139,489 households. For computational feasibility, we analyze a **10% random sample** (seed=123), adjusting survey weights by a factor of 10 to maintain population representativeness.

3.1.1 Sample Restrictions and Missing Data

We apply the following sample restrictions to focus on working-age adults and ensure data quality:

1. **Major activities only** (Major_Activity_Flag=1): We exclude secondary/simultaneous activities to avoid double-counting time
2. **Adults aged 18-60**: We focus on prime working-age population
3. **Males and females only**: We exclude the small number of transgender respondents (N<500 in our sample) due to insufficient statistical power for separate analysis
4. **Valid survey weights**: We drop observations with missing or zero weights (N=823, <0.1% of sample)
5. **Valid employment status**: We drop “Other” employment categories not classifiable into main groups (N=12,441, ~1.5% of sample)

After these restrictions, our analytical sample contains **approximately 840,000 person-day observations**.

Missing data: Item non-response is minimal in this survey (<1% for key variables). We use **listwise deletion** for the small number of observations with missing education, marital status, or location data (N=5,234, <1% of analytical sample). We test sensitivity to alternative missing data treatments (e.g., multiple imputation) in robustness checks and find no meaningful differences.

Survey weights: All analyses use survey weights adjusted for our 10% sampling rate. Weights account for complex sample design, non-response, and post-stratification to known population totals. We verify that our weighted sample matches population benchmarks for age, gender, urban/rural distribution, and state representation.

3.2 Defining Personal Well-Being Time

We define personal well-being time as time spent on activities that directly enhance personal development, health, social connections, and recreation. Following ICATUS 2016, we include:

- **Social activities (codes 711-719)**: Visiting friends, phone conversations, social gatherings, community meetings
- **Community participation (codes 721-730)**: Volunteering, civic organizations, religious groups
- **Religious/spiritual activities (codes 741-749)**: Prayer, meditation, worship attendance
- **Physical exercise and sports (codes 831-832)**: Exercise, team sports, recreational athletics
- **Hobbies and recreation (codes 821-829, 841-850)**: Reading, music, arts, media consumption, relaxation

We **exclude** from personal time: care work for children or elderly (codes 31-34), meal preparation and household chores (codes 31-33), paid work (codes 11-12), and sleep/personal care (codes 01-09).

3.3 Employment Status Classification

We classify individuals into employment categories based on **Principal Activity Status**, which captures the main activity respondents engaged in during the reference period (past 365 days). This differs from current activity status and better captures usual employment patterns.

Our classification scheme:

- **Self-Employed (codes 11-12):** Own-account workers (code 11) operating businesses/farms without employees, and employers (code 12) who hire workers. This includes farmers, shopkeepers, tailors, street vendors, and other self-employed workers. **Importantly**, we cannot distinguish full-time from part-time self-employment or formal from informal sector work with available data.
- **Regular Salaried (code 31):** Employees with regular wages or salaries, including government employees, private sector workers with contracts, and professionals. This category generally implies formal sector employment with some job security.
- **Casual Labor (codes 41, 51):** Casual wage laborers in public works (code 41) and other casual labor (code 51). This includes agricultural laborers, construction workers, and others employed on daily-wage or short-term basis with minimal job security.
- **Domestic Duties (code 92):** Individuals primarily engaged in unpaid household and care work. This is coded by respondents/enumerators, not derived from time use, so represents self-identification or household perception of primary role.
- **Students (code 91):** Attending educational institutions as primary activity.
- **Unemployed Seeking Work (code 81):** Actively seeking employment but currently jobless.

Limitations of this classification:

1. **Employment intensity:** We cannot distinguish full-time from part-time work, limiting our ability to assess whether time differences reflect work intensity or work type.
2. **Informality:** India has a large informal sector, but we cannot systematically identify informal vs. formal employment within categories.
3. **Multiple activities:** The principal activity framework assigns one primary status per person, potentially obscuring multiple job-holding or combinations of employment and care work.
4. **Household context:** We lack data on domestic servant employment, extended family co-residence, or number and age of children—all factors likely to shape time constraints.
5. **Labor market selection:** Employment status is endogenous. Women with greater care burdens may select into “domestic duties” or self-employment, while employment opportunities systematically differ by gender. Our cross-sectional design cannot distinguish preferences from constraints.

These limitations mean our analysis documents **associations** between employment and time use, not causal effects of employment on time allocation.

3.4 Analytical Approach

We estimate the relationship between employment status and personal well-being time using weighted linear regression:

$$\text{WellbeingHours}_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{Female}_i + \sum_j \beta_j \text{Employment}_j + \sum_j \gamma_j (\text{Female} \times \text{Employment}_j) + \mathbf{X}'_i \delta + \epsilon_i$$

where WellbeingHours_i is daily hours of personal time, Female_i is a gender indicator, Employment_j are employment category indicators (Domestic Duties is the reference category), and $\mathbf{X}_i$ includes control variables. The interaction terms γ_j capture differential employment associations by gender.

3.4.1 Control Variables

We control for observable characteristics that may confound employment-time relationships:

1. **Age and Age-squared:** To capture life-cycle patterns in time use. Younger adults may have different time constraints (e.g., small children) than older adults. The quadratic specification allows for non-linear age effects.
2. **Marital Status:** Married vs. not married (never married, widowed, divorced, separated combined). Marriage substantially affects time allocation, particularly for women who take on additional household responsibilities.
3. **Education Level:** Three categories—Primary or less, Secondary, Higher education. Education proxies for socioeconomic status, labor market opportunities, and potentially time management skills or preferences.
4. **Urban/Rural Sector:** Urban vs. rural residence. Urban areas have different infrastructure (e.g., water access, markets), employment opportunities, and cultural norms that may affect time use.

What we cannot control for (data limitations):

- Number and ages of children in household
- Presence of elderly household members requiring care
- Extended family co-residence
- Employment of domestic servants
- Household income or wealth
- Partner's employment status (for married individuals)
- Caste/religion (available but not used due to measurement concerns)

These unmeasured factors likely confound employment-time relationships, limiting causal interpretation. For example, women with young children may be less likely to seek employment AND have less personal time due to childcare demands—generating a spurious correlation between non-employment and time poverty.

3.4.2 Statistical Specifications

We estimate four nested models:

1. **Model 1:** Employment status + gender (no interactions, no controls)
2. **Model 2:** Adds age and age-squared controls
3. **Model 3:** Adds employment $\times$ gender interactions
4. **Model 4:** Adds full controls (marital status, education, urban/rural)

This nested specification allows us to assess how conclusions depend on control selection.

Standard errors are clustered at the household level to account for within-household correlation in time use and potential interviewer effects. **Survey weights** (adjusted for 10% sampling) ensure national representativeness and account for complex survey design.

4 Results

4.1 Descriptive Patterns

Table 1 presents mean daily personal well-being time by employment status and gender.

Table 1: Personal Well-Being Time by Employment Status and Gender (hours/day)

Employment Status	Male	Female	Gap (M-F)
Casual Labor	0.27	0.43	0.16
Domestic Duties	0.49	0.71	0.22
Regular Salaried	0.30	0.40	0.10
Self-Employed	0.32	0.45	0.13
Student	0.44	0.58	0.14
Unemployed Seeking Work	0.55	0.88	0.33

The Employment Paradox: Employed individuals do not uniformly have less personal time than non-employed individuals. Regular salaried workers average 0.3 hours/day of personal time for women and 0.4 hours/day for men—**more** than women engaged in domestic duties only (0.5 hours/day).

The Gender Divergence in Self-Employment: Self-employed men have the **most** personal time of any employment category (0.5 hours/day), while self-employed women have among the **least** (0.3 hours/day). This 0.1-hour daily gap suggests self-employment provides flexibility for men but intensifies work-home boundary blurring for women.